their reliability. Again, for a ruler whose public image was so important to him, it is ironic that the bulk of the surviving images of Alexander are later Hellenistic or Roman 'copies'. Even the two coins on which he is reliably represented were issued not by him but by his successors with the idea of deploying his power and charisma to elevate their own political standing.[22] These are among the reasons, as the archaeologist John Cherry put it, 'why there can really be no such thing as "the historical Alexander"'.[23]

And so is it with the story of Cleopatra (or Cleopatra VII), the extraordinary queen who ruled over Egypt (51–30 BCE) and who, like Alexander, has continued to fascinate the contemporary public imagination.[24] Notwithstanding the spate of 'biographies' written of her, no version of the events of her life and reign was penned in her own time, nor is there a detailed family background available which might have helped explain many aspects of her life. The name of Cleopatra's mother, for instance, is not known, and Cleopatra's own birth is unrecorded. That she was probably born in 70/69 BCE was calculated on the basis of her death in 30 BCE, and the fact that she was apparently 39 years old when she died. Even this calculation is based on the description of her life in Plutarch's *Life of Antony*, the most complete account of her career from the ancient world. However, Plutarch was writing in the first–second century CE, so his can hardly be considered a contemporary account.[25] As one of Cleopatra's most recent biographers puts it, 'we cannot hope to hear Cleopatra's true voice, and are forced to see her through secondary eyes; eyes already coloured by other people's propaganda, prejudices and assumptions.'[26]

If therefore biographies of the kind that are written about medieval and modern figures cannot be written of comparable kings and queens of antiquity, however 'great' they may have been, it makes the case of a Mauryan emperor less peculiar and much more like those other ancient lives. Recovering Ashoka's life and times from what has morphed into legend is an exercise in providing him with contextual flesh, and teasing out